

Flipping The Switch

The third round started the same as the previous two. Cole was content to pad her jab and stay out of range. Danni was trying to stay patient, while waiting for something to react to. The lack of activity left me plenty of time to properly adjust my point of view. I had been so blind... so wound up and worried that something terrible might happen... that I'd spent the first two rounds seeing things that weren't there. Trying like hell to figure out Cole's mysterious strategy, when, in fact, there had been no mystery at all. It was as plain as the nose on my face... and, in its own warped way, it made perfect sense. I had even said it myself.

Danni was as sharp and prepared as I had ever seen her. She had shredded her early round opponents, and handled Megan Fox like an expert. She wasn't just ready for Cheryl Cole. She was ready for anything. Striking, grappling, wrestling, judo... go ahead and pick your poison. Danni had seen it all in training these past few months, while being tested by some of the best in the business. She was completely on her game. Totally unstoppable. No fighter in her right mind would want to deal with her when she was this zoned in.

That included the vaunted Cheryl Cole... which is why she was doing everything she could to avoid it now.

The idea was simple... to do damage, you have to risk taking some. Danni had spent four rounds of this tournament punishing anyone willing to take that chance against her. So Cole was trying something totally different. Instead of looking to do damage, she was trying to load up on the most controversial statistic in MMA.

Octagonal control.

The intent is to give credit to the fighter who seems to be controlling the action. Not a bad idea on the surface, but how that control is measured is a very subjective thing. Some say the fighter driving the action most of the time is the one in control. But what if the other fighter is having more success with her counter strikes? Isn't that a form of control? Likewise, is the fighter attempting a takedown considered to be in control, even if she gets stuffed?

These problems usually iron themselves out. After all, a fighter who is consistently beating an opponent with her counter game will get credit for more effective striking. A fighter who repeatedly thwarts her opponent's takedowns will probably be able to make some opportunities of her own. Above all, the fighter doing the most damage will almost always end up taking control as the fight wears on. So the stat only becomes an issue when fights are extremely close.

But what if one fighter was deliberately keeping things close? What if she was also using cheap tricks to make sure she was almost always the one in control?

That's the gameplan Cole and her team were going with tonight. A deliberately slow and stifling approach that had nothing to do with fighting, and everything to do with appearances. It was meant to keep Danni off-balance, and allow Cheryl to look like the one in command. And it was working.

It was an approach that was widely panned. A cowardly strategy deployed by a fighter who knew she was in over her head, using tactics so detested that they had well-known and very unflattering names. Those sloppy takedowns and all that useless grappling on the canvas were commonly referred to as *lay and pray*. Because that's what you do. Get your opponent to the canvas any way you can, then lay on top of her and don't let her up. Try a little something here and there, but only enough to show you're alive and keep the ref out it. The whole idea is to waste as much time as possible with you in control, and then pray the judges hand you the decision.

And that silly grope-fest against the cage? They call that *wall and stall*. Different position. Same idea. Pin your opponent to the fence and keep her there. Then show just enough activity to placate the ref while you kill clock.

In a strange way, it all came across as a form of respect from Cole. This was amateur-hour shit. Even if she managed to win this thing, she was going to hear it from all sides. She would be a laughing stock... and yet she was doing it anyway. That's how badly she wanted to avoid going toe-to-toe with Danni.

Speaking of Ms. Harris... I had no doubt she and Steph were already way ahead of me on this, but knowing what Cheryl was doing was only half the battle. Sloppy-takedown, silly-grappling, pushing-and-shoving Cheryl Cole might be a laughing stock, but punch-your-lights-out, smash-your-face-in, knock-you-stupid Cheryl Cole was still hiding behind the facade. If Danni let her guard down in order to deal with this time-wasting nonsense, Cole could quickly and easily put her on the canvas for good. She had already tried it once... and had nearly gotten her head knocked off as a result. So she had no choice. She had to stay within her gameplan, and respect the things she knew Cheryl could do well.

Which left her pretty much stuck.

What she needed was a way to change things up. To hit Cole with something big and unexpected. Something that would knock her off her smother and control strategy.

As it happens, she did have just such a weapon in her arsenal. A surprise Cole would never see coming, but Danni was too obstinate to use.

And I was the only one in the arena who knew about it.

But what could I do? Should I go down there?

No. Absolutely not. That would be crazy. Steph was the one in charge on the floor, and she was the best there was. She and Danni worked perfectly together. No rational owner would interfere with that. Especially in such a big moment.

In the cage, Cole launched an actual, significant attack for the first time in the round - pushing forward behind a strong combination. Danni defended the punches beautifully, then looked to counter. But Cheryl had already gone low. Looking for another takedown. Danni got herself ready, but Cole pushed straight into her waiting defense anyway. They shoved each other around for a while, then Cole came up swinging. Danni had to step back to dodge the blow... which gave Cole the chance to retreat to safety.

Another skirmish won by Cheryl Cole... even though she didn't land a damn thing.

This shit had to stop.

I glanced at the round timer. Just over three minutes to go.

Then I made up my mind.

The evolution of our relationship has made me many things to Danni. Boss, training partner, friend... and now, much more than that. Those roles often clash with each other, leaving me to question which capacity I was supposed to act in when. But right now, they were all in perfect harmony.

Without a word to the others, I got up and left. Because I've been called a lot of things... and rational has never been one of them.

* * *

I made great time getting downstairs because the concourse was empty. Everyone was watching the fight. I badged my way onto the arena floor with just over twenty seconds left in the round. Nothing of consequence had happened while I was making my way down, but there had been a torturous moment when I heard the crowd noise start to rise, only to have it drop off just as quickly. Apparently Cole had pressed forward and let loose with another series of combinations. The aggressiveness of the attack had brought the fans into it, but Danni's defense had held - which let the air out of the balloon. Now, the two fighters were back to pawing at each other to little effect as the round drew to a close.

As I approached the cage, I could see the team was ready. Marcy and Amanda had their gear up on the apron, giving everything a last look before they sprung into action. Steph had her eyes focused on the fighters, and you could see the wheels turning as she formulated what she would say during the break.

All eyes turned to me in surprise when I stepped up beside them. They were even more surprised by what I had to say.

"I'm going in on the next break," I said.

All three looked at me like I was crazy. Then Steph's expression hardened, and the color started to rise in her face.

"You taking my spot?" Mandy asked in confusion.

"No. You and Marcy just do your thing and forget I'm there."

I brought my eyes up to Steph's.

"I need you to let me handle this one," I said.

She turned a deeper shade of crimson.

I was treading on sacred territory. The time in the corner is for fighter and coach. Period, end of story. Too many voices only cause confusion. For us, Steph's is the voice that matters. It's her role and her responsibility to be the steady navigator for our fighters, and she takes it as seriously as she possibly can.

The bell rang to close the round, and Amanda and Marcy started for the cage door. I moved to follow, but Steph grabbed my arm.

"I know what I'm asking," I said before she had the chance to speak. "I need you to trust me."

That did nothing to sway her, and the clock was ticking. I stated my case as quickly and plainly as I could.

"Cole is fucking with her," I said. "I can help. She can do things you don't know about."

Right away, I knew I'd made an impact. She knew what Cheryl was doing, and she knew it was working. This fight was slowly slipping away, and we were running out of time to get it turned around. Steph had given Danni whatever help she could, but it hadn't been enough. She was grasping for a solution, and now I was claiming I had one.

"Steph, it's Danni," I pleaded. "I promised I wouldn't let her down again, and I'm not going to."

Her expression told me I'd scored again. She took another brief second to make up her mind. Then she gave a quick nod, and we both hurried into the cage.

Marcy and Amanda were already getting to work when we entered. Danni was looking our way - likely wondering what the hell happened to Steph - and she made a face as soon as she saw me.

"What the..."

I waved her off. Time was short and we'd already wasted some of it.

"Nothing is wrong, so don't worry about it," I said. "In fact, you look great out there. Cole's trying every trick in the book, and the way you've been dealing with it is amazing."

She looked disgusted.

"I expect just about anything from that bitch," she said with a nod toward Cole, "but this..."

"I know. But the problem is it's working. You're losing this fight," I said.

"I know," she admitted. "She's been so unpredictable. I can't get ahead of her."

She sounded nothing like last time. There was no defeat in her voice. She knew what was happening, and she was simply giving her team the facts. Looking to us for the solutions we're supposed to provide.

I nodded solidly and got to work on giving her some.

"She's trying to keep you confused and not let you attack."

"We know," she said with a gesture toward Steph, "but we're running out of ideas."

"You have to get off your back foot," I said. "You use defense to create offense. That's always been your way. Cole knows that and she's using it against you. If you're gonna beat her, you have to start taking the initiative."

"I'm trying, but there are no openings. She's just tying me up with this stalling bullshit. When I push back, she starts swinging. Everything I try gets me in trouble."

"You need a way to force her to open up," I said. "Some incredible new technique she won't see coming."

She looked at me like I was nuts.

"How am I going..."

There was a split-second of confusion, then her eyes locked onto mine as she got the message.

"I told you..."

"I know what you told me," I interrupted. "Now, I'm here to tell you different. You can work it in, smooth as glass. Cole isn't going to know what hit her."

"I..."

"Look, we don't have a lot of time to discuss this, and I didn't come all the way down here to have a debate. You need to get her off of you, and I'm telling you this is how you do it. It's why I made you keep practicing it. And don't try to tell me you didn't know that's what I was doing."

"Yeah, but that was for later. Months from now."

"Fuck that," I said. "It's ready now, and you know it."

She looked up and our eyes locked again. Everything around us faded away. The crowd noise was deafening. The cageside commentators were prattling away. Marcy was busy doing her thing. But neither of us noticed any of it. It was like an invisible bubble had formed around us, and, for a long moment, it was just her and me. And there was no doubt we both wanted the same thing.

Danni had already proven so much at this event. She had beaten Amanda in a fight that was as emotionally trying as it was physically demanding. She had owned Megan Fox like she was nothing. Without a doubt, she had dispelled the myths and rumors that had been floating around her. Her last fight with Cole had not been the beginning of the end for her. It had been nothing more than a rare letdown in an outstanding career that was clearly far from over. Even if she lost this fight, no one was going to drag her down because of it. Cole's cheap tactics were obvious, and you don't get any credit for fighting like a chicken. Everyone would know she had conned her way into a hollow victory over a superior fighter.

But, seeing her now, I knew it wasn't enough for Danni to have silenced her doubters. She wanted the win. She needed to complete the circle of her comeback, and Cole and her bullshit were standing in the way.

As for me... I had never felt so strongly about a fight I wasn't in. Obviously, I wanted Danni to win, but it was more than that. I *needed* it. When this was over, I needed her to be able to sit and face the media with her hard-earned trophy laying right there on the table for all to see. Letting it tell the world what she would never say.

And I wanted Cheryl Cole to...

"I'll try it," Danni said with a nod.

I snapped out of my thoughts and nodded back at her.

"Smooth," I instructed. "Just like with me. And break it out early. I doubt she'll be able to figure out what's happening on the fly, but her corner will probably catch on. So give yourself the whole round to work with before they can help her."

She nodded again.

I glanced over my shoulder and saw the ref heading our way. Danni turned and let Amanda slide her mouthpiece back in.

"One last thing. I know you don't let Cheryl's big mouth bother you, but your teammates and I are totally sick of it. We're sick of the lies. We're sick of the smartass remarks. We're sick of her shit. So, could you please do us a favor, and shut her the fuck up?"

I balled my right hand into a fist, and held it out in front of me. Danni smiled, then tapped it with hers, knuckle to knuckle.

"Go get her," I said.

* * *

Steph was waiting for me when I hit the floor.

"I'm officially lifting your ban," she said. "You're welcome in the cage any time you like."

"We'll see about that," I said - the image of the bloodied and beaten Danni from the last fight still vivid in my mind.

As we walked to our places at cageside, I glanced up and found Danni looking right at me. We exchanged confident nods, and, in that moment, any doubts I still harbored disappeared.

She's gonna win this thing.

"So," Steph said, "you want to tell me what the hell you two were talking about?"

"Nah," I said. "It'll be more fun as a surprise."

She made no attempt to hide the growling noise she made at that. Steph doesn't like surprises.

The bell rang, and the two fighters began to circle as they closed the distance on each other. As soon as Danni was in range, Cole snapped out the jab, then the cross. Danni defended both, scored with a jab of her own, then slid away.

They circled some more. When the distance closed, Cole quickly launched the same combo. This time, Danni responded immediately - tucking her chin and keeping her shoulder high as she fired her own jab into the middle of Cheryl's sequence. The posture kept her out of danger as Cole's cross glanced harmlessly off of her shoulder. Meanwhile, the element of surprise gave Danni's jab a little something extra, and she tried to capitalize by sneaking a straight right over the top. Cole managed to angle her head out of the way, but she immediately recognized she was in a dangerous position and retreated. It seemed like a prime opportunity for Danni to press her, but she was content to simply reset her guard for the next exchange.

Twice more, Cole tried to control the action with the combo, only to slink away after being chastened by Danni's jab. Yet Danni repeatedly failed to follow-up.

I smiled as I realized what was going on.

She was ignoring my request to make use of her new weapon early in the round, but I could see she had a slightly different plan... and I kind of liked it.

"What the fuck is she doing?" Steph asked.

"She's feeding her the jab."

"Yeah, but she's wasting her chances."

"Nope," I said. "She's setting her up."

The jab is an effective weapon in almost every situation. Not only is it the gateway to countless offensive attacks, but it is also an important form of defense. A quick punch you can use to aggravate and disrupt an

opponent and force her to abandon whatever attack she'd been trying to launch. The punch is so useful that it's very common for a fighter to become too reliant on it. To fall in love with it, as they say. The problem then is that you become predictable and easier for your opponent to manage.

And that's exactly the impression Danni was trying to give. Because if Cheryl thought Danni was getting predictable, she would be more willing to throw caution to the wind and go for something big.

The other - probably larger - benefit was that constantly pecking at Cole with the left would get her looking that way. Watching for the jab and trying to time her counter.

For a brief moment, I felt bad for Steph. There was no way she could understand what was happening because she didn't know all that Danni could do. That would be a frustrating situation for anyone. For someone like Steph... I was willing to bet she was on the verge of bursting a blood vessel.

"Setting her up for *what?*" she asked.

"Just hang in there."

Twice more, they went through the routine. By then, even I was a little confused. Cole was eying the jab closely. Eager for a chance to pounce. That was exactly the way Danni wanted her, so why hadn't she made her move?

Everything changed on the next sequence, but the way it started had nothing to do with any surprise Danni sprung. It was just pure awesomeness.

Cole jabbed lightly from range, and Danni immediately responded with her own left hand. Cole saw it, slipped it, then crouched low and lunged in for another takedown. That's when I found out what Danni had been waiting on. After three rounds of this nonsense, she'd clearly had enough... and she decided to let Cheryl know it in a big way. As Cole sprang forward, the RSI leader let the cross fly on a downward angle. Had Cheryl been upright, it would have hit the center of her chest. Squatted down the way she was, it hit her square in the face.

The force of the blow turned Cole's forward momentum sideways - allowing Danni to easily slip away while leaving her opponent awkwardly struggling on all-fours to keep from falling down. It was far and away her best counter of the night... breaking up the attack and doing quite a bit of damage in the process. And it had the added benefit of making Cheryl look pretty stupid as she scrambled away.

Once Cole gathered herself, she came up angry and frustrated. She set her glare on Danni, who stood with her guard up - looking cool and composed.

And I'll be damned if she wasn't smiling a little, too.

The sight of Danni's grin had Cole breathing fire and looking to get even. Her corner was busy yelling at her to stay patient and focused. The commentators were engrossed in a little competition to see just how many silly catch-phrases they could use to describe the weird scrabbling Cheryl had been forced into.

Meanwhile, nobody noticed the way Danni had quietly changed her stance.

"She switched her feet," Steph said.

I stand corrected.

But spotting the switch only made RSI's head of training that much more concerned.

"This is not the time for this," she said. "You can't play games with someone like Cole."

"She's not playing."

Her expression was doubtful. As if any strategy that had not been personally approved by her could not possibly be game-ready.

"Just watch, Steph."

The fruits of Danni's labor were now obvious. All that jabbing had killed a lot of clock, but it also gotten Cheryl in just the right frame of mind. Then came that pretty-as-a-picture counter and the degrading crawling around that followed. It was all too much for Cole's enormously swollen ego to bear. Now, she suddenly looked like the Cheryl we all knew... and I became convinced this plan had never been her idea to begin with. Not that I was going to let her off the hook because she was the one who'd gone out there and done it, but it was clear it must have come from her team. They'd reviewed Danni's fights from the earlier rounds and realized this was a fighter they didn't want to fuck with. They scrambled for an alternate approach, and they somehow sold this nonsense to Cheryl. But playing these games must have taken a toll on her, too. It was not her way, and constantly having to fight her natural instincts could not have been easy. She'd put up with it while it was working, but that counter... no one humiliates Cheryl Cole that way. Points be damned, she wanted Danni's head on a platter.

Perfect, I smiled to myself.

Cole charged in behind the jab, with her right hand already loaded. But anger hadn't made her stupid, and she was keeping a close eye on Danni's left. Waiting for the nearly obligatory jab in response.

Then it came and smashed into the other side of her head.

The punch landed with decent power, and the shock of having it come from the wrong side threw Cole out of whack immediately. If I didn't hate her so much I'd have felt bad for her because I remember what that first time felt like. When Danni followed with the cross - now coming via her left hand - Cheryl's defense was completely out of position. Danni's fist landed untouched on the point of the singer's chin. Immediately she pivoted and threw the right hook. With Cole having no clue what was happening, Danni found her target again - driving the punch into the side of Cheryl's head and sending her staggering across the cage.

"Huh," Steph said.

That, in case you missed it, was the sound of Steph McMahon being impressed.

As Cheryl reeled, Danni surged forward to stay on her. And with the first step she took, she switched back to her normal stance.

Cole tried to gather her defense, but Danni was there with a big right hand that wrenched the Brit's head sideways. Cheryl set her feet and immediately responded with her own right. Sticking with the all-out offensive approach she was known for. Danni made her pay by slipping the punch and rocking her with a bone-breaking left hook to the head.

Cole lost her footing as the punch sent her reeling. For a brief second, I thought she was going down, but she proved her toughness again - getting her legs under her while continuing to move. That last part was key. She might not have known exactly what was happening to her, but she suddenly knew what was most important. She needed to get the hell away from Danni so she could figure things out.

Danni knew it too, and there was no way she was going to let it happen. And as she stalked after her prey, it took me a second to realize she was in her left-handed posture, once again.

Beside me, Steph quietly shook her head.

"It's amazing, isn't it?" I asked.

"I don't understand why you didn't tell me she could do it," she answered. "We could have made it part of her strategy from the start."

"She was being a pain in the ass," I answered. "No matter how good she got, she didn't feel confident in it."

Danni threw the Southpaw one-two again, both punches landing untouched. Poor Cheryl took the hits and just kept moving, desperate to stay away. But that's the thing about fighting inside a locked cage. You can't run for long.

And Danni was coming again.

"She's insane," Steph said. "She's got plenty of power from either stance, and there's no awkwardness to give anything away. The switch is so smooth, she looks like she's been doing it since birth. I've never seen it done better."

"I've never seen it done, period."

"There are plenty of fighters who do it," she scoffed.

"Danni said that too, but she couldn't give me any examples."

"Roy Jones... Marvin Hagler... Oscar De La Hoya.... Floyd Mayweather... Alistair Overeem... Meisha Tate... Rose Namajunas... Tecia Torres..."

"Fuck you, Steph," I interrupted. "Why do you have to know everything?"

"I don't have to know everything."

She was quiet for just a moment, and then...

"I just do," she finished.

What could I say? She does.

With Cheryl on the run, Danni stayed in the Southpaw stance. Trying to maximize the confusion until she had her cornered. Then she would switch back to access all of her power.

Meanwhile, say what you want about Cole, she had good people behind her. Her corner had already figured out what was happening, and I heard someone over there scream, "Watch the right!"

It was a valiant effort, but ultimately pointless. Having been the one doing the fighting myself, I knew Cheryl was too preoccupied to hear a word they were saying. And, even if she did, what sense would it make? Most importantly, what could Cole do about it? Practice makes perfect, and she'd worked hard and long to prepare for Danni's tendencies. Which meant there was no way she could be ready for this outstanding new wrinkle.

Showing a renewed energy, Danni chased the retreating Cheryl all around the cage. Not knowing which end was up, Cole had her head on a swivel. Great fighters rely heavily on instinct, but Cheryl's instincts were currently getting her killed. So, she had been forced to switch to manual mode - repeatedly peeking out from behind her guard to try and spot what was coming. Danni was free to pick her shots. Find the opening, hit the opening. As simple as a game of Whac-A-Mole at a Wildwood boardwalk arcade. A couple of times, Cole got frustrated and tried to punch her way out of trouble. Not automatically a bad idea, but definitely the wrong move against Danni. Dodge and counter was her specialty, and Cheryl lashing out was only making her life easier. And once she was sure Cole was good and ready, she settled back into her normal stance and the beating got serious.

A right hand opened the assault. Cheryl was already shying away from an anticipated jab and walked right into the punch with her guard out of shape. Danni's fist went right through... and straight into Cole's left eye. Cheryl brought her guard up higher. Danni put a pair of punches into her belly. The guard inched back down, and Danni snuck a left over the top. Cole took two big, desperate swings. Danni dodged them easily, but Cheryl gained enough space to slip away.

The damage was adding up and it was starting to show. The clean right hand had torn the skin under Cole's eye, and a thin line of blood ran down her cheek. Some swelling was visible, as well. The silver lining - if you could call it that - was there was less than a minute left in the round. Meaning there was a chance Cheryl's corner could get a handle on the problem before it got out of control.

Of course, that would only matter if Danni didn't kill her first.

But Cole knew the situation and she put all her energy into staying out of Danni's path. It worked for a while... to the point where it started to get aggravating. Cheryl was just about ready to go... and I wanted her gone, right now.

Danni - who is infinitely more patient than I am - stayed the course. Circling and jabbing. Cutting off the cage and slowly tightening the noose.

She finally pinned her down again just before the clacker sounded. Good movement had backed Cheryl toward the mesh. Danni took a lunging step right and Cole reacted in the other direction. Then Danni did a neat little slide back to the left and Cheryl's goose was cooked.

Again Danni skipped the jab and went straight to the right hand. The left followed immediately. Cole was still playing read-and-react, and it just wasn't enough. Danni was too fast and too precise. Both punches got through, driving Cheryl into the fence. Danni let loose. Two punches to the gut, then two more upstairs. All four came as a set. Thrown without hesitation, and landing with authority.

BOOM, BOOM, BOOM, BOOM!

Cole was both actively defending and practically helpless. She knew what she needed to do but it wasn't working. Danni was beating her with everything. She simply could not keep up.

Danni shot a left hand downstairs. Score. A right hand landed flush on Cole's already damaged eye. Then the left hook whipped Cheryl's around in a spray of blood and sweat.

The bell sounded and Yi - who had been primed and waiting - immediately threw herself between the two fighters.

Cole was motionless for a few seconds. Long enough that I thought she might be out. Then she slowly dragged herself up off the fence, and slunk off to her corner. She stole only a quick glance at Danni, who was standing right there with a friendly little smile on her face.

See ya soon, Cheryl!

* * *

As I followed the others to the cage door, I did some quick math.

Though they were all close, I was certain the judges had scored at least one of the first three rounds for Cole. My pessimistic nature told me they'd probably given her two. But this round had been Danni from wire to wire... starting with the way she had brutally turned Cheryl aside on the takedown attempt.

If the judges had given Cole the edge early, then fair play said they had to give this one to Danni in a landslide. I scored it ten-eight in her favor, which meant they were all square with one to go and Danni on a roll.

We arrived at our spot at nearly the same moment Danni did. Unsurprisingly, she looked fresher and more energized than she had during the previous break.

She tongued her mouthpiece forward for Mandy to grab, then smiled at me and said, "*That* was fun."

"Fun to watch, too," I agreed.

And that was the last we said on it. A one minute break doesn't leave a lot of time for small talk.

"Alright," I said. "I can see her team knows what you were doing, but I'm not sure that's a bad thing."

She looked a little puzzled.

"When I said I was obsessed with the switch, that wasn't a lie. I was constantly watching for it. Meanwhile, you were busy beating the shit out of me from your normal stance."

"Yeah, that was fun, too," she quipped.

"Point is, you know how to handle this. If she's watching, play it straight. If she gets comfortable, switch it up. You're in her head now, and I don't think there's anything her corner can say that will change that."

She nodded as she took a long pull from the water bottle Mandy provided.

"Just don't let it become a distraction to you," I continued. "If you feel like it's taking you out of your rhythm, just stay orthodox. You don't need any help to win. You can beat her straight on."

My frankness seemed to surprise her a little.

"You're better than she is," I shrugged, "and don't think she doesn't know it. She saw the way you mopped the cage with everybody else, and she knew she was in deep shit. That's why she tried to nickel and dime you to death instead of taking you on."

Danni looked to Steph, who gave a little nod of agreement.

"You guys sure know how to make a girl feel good," Danni said.

We spent the rest of the break fine-tuning the strategy. Now that Steph was in on the secret, I deferred most of the attention to her. Meanwhile, Marcy spent the time treating the few minor marks and bruises Danni had suffered, while Amanda handled the scut work.

"I have one more favor to ask," I said as the ref signaled the seconds out of the cage.

Danni looked at me expectantly, and I leaned over and whispered in her ear.

When I drew my head back, she was staring straight at me with no hint of amusement on her face. Just hard seriousness.

I met her gaze with a matching expression. We had just connected on a new and very exclusive level. One of those things where you had to live through it to truly understand.

She nodded. Just a single, nearly undetectable tilt of her head. I gave her one back, then followed the others out of the cage.

When I looked up this time, Danni wasn't looking at me. Instead she was glaring coldly across the cage at her opponent. Cheryl saw her and held the stare for a moment, then abruptly looked away.

I smiled at the sight.

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Whatever advice Cole's corner had given her didn't help because the final round started out the same way the previous one had ended. Danni switched her stance a few times. Cheryl was more alert to it, but didn't seem to know what to do about it when she saw it. And while she was busy keeping a close eye on Danni's posture, Danni was simply pounding away at her. No matter what Cole did, she just couldn't seem to figure out where the punches were coming from, and Danni was getting the better of her on every exchange.

Cheryl tried all she could to turn it around. Twice, she threw away all semblance of defense and just went for it - launching vicious, fight-ending punches out of nowhere. But Danni wasn't stupid. Everything was going her way and she had a whole round to work with. She could afford to be careful. Cheryl was the one who had to take risks, and Danni made her pay for it, every time.

Time ticked by. Cole kept trying, but got nowhere. Danni's defense was impregnable, and there were no holes in her confidence, either. She never gave an inch when Cheryl went on the attack. Instead, she stayed in close and relied on the things she did best. Bending and twisting. Using small, expert movements to make her opponent miss by inches, then bringing the pain with her punishing counter game.

Say what you want about her tactics, Cole had the right idea at the start. Avoiding Danni was the only winning play. Cheryl didn't want any of this... because she simply wasn't good enough. The last fight had been a mirage. A product of circumstances instead of talent and experience... and Cole had fallen for it. She came out truly believing she was better, and she had spent the intervening months reminding everyone of that fact as loudly and frequently as she could. Building herself up as the queen. Now she was learning the truth the hard way, as Danni tore her little dream world apart... one precise blow at a time.

If I didn't hate her so much, I might have felt bad for her. But I had no capacity for sympathy now... because I was having too much fun watching her get destroyed.

As the Brit fell apart, Danni locked into her normal stance. There was no need for confusion anymore. It was all about power, now.

Her combinations got more daring. What was two punches before became three or four. Cole was hanging by a thread, and Danni's killer instinct was kicking in.

The next three exchanges were either glorious or dismal, depending on which fighter you were rooting for. Things were getting easier for Danni. Cheryl was beaten, bloodied and running out of steam. Too slow to get away. Too exhausted to fight back effectively. Danni was dictating... changing levels in expert fashion and creating her own holes in Cole's defense. A fight that had been a complete joke only minutes ago had now become an absolute pasting. The damage mounted quickly, and it wasn't long before the evidence started to show all over Cheryl's face.

Suddenly, Cole let loose with a pair of desperate, haymaker style swings - one with each hand. Danni saw them coming and swayed out of range, but Cheryl was quick to make use of the small amount of space - squeezing her way along the mesh as she slid free to her right. Danni didn't let her go easily... tagging her with another left on the way out. Cheryl took the blow right on the point of her chin. The impact snapped her head sideways, but she kept moving. Urgently focused on getting out of Danni's kill zone. Once she did, she just kept going - retreating as far as the steel enclosure would allow.

As the two fighters reset, Cole had no hope of hiding the emotion that was roiling inside her. Her posture bent and curled, like she just wanted to roll into a ball. Her eyes darting around the cage - carefully watching Danni while also looking for angles of escape. It all pointed to the obvious truth.

Cheryl Cole didn't want to fight anymore.

Danni's surge over these final two rounds had blown away everything that had happened before, and she was well on her way to a second two-point advantage here in the final frame. Even if the judges had scored all three early rounds for Cheryl, she was behind now in the closing minutes. There was no question she needed to do something. To attack relentlessly and apply every ounce of pressure she could muster in the hope that Danni would make a fatal mistake. Instead, she was hanging back, trying to keep as much distance between them as possible. Giving up on her only remaining chance to win, with a look on her face that said it all.

Please make it stop.

It was a look I'd seen not long ago in a place I'd never expected to find it. Because of all the things she'd said about the last fight, it was the one word Danni had never uttered that bothered me most. A word both of us had been tacitly dancing around, but neither had actually said.

She had been *afraid*.

Given who she is and what she's done, it's a hard thing to imagine. But I knew it was possible because I had been there.

It's one thing to lose a fight. That's just part of the deal. You bring your best, and your opponent brings hers. Then you put it out there and see what's what. She gets you good, you buckle down and get her back. Find a way to stop her, then make her wish she'd never gotten in there with you. If it doesn't work out for you in the end... well that's too bad. Work harder. Get stronger. Try again.

But there are times when rationalization like that doesn't work. When your opponent is out there pummeling you... literally beating you to a pulp... and you have no answers. You can't stop her. You can't get her back. Nothing you trying is working, and she's hurting you bad. When that's happening, and you're just in there helplessly waiting for the end... it is a very scary thing.

Losing like that leaves a deep and permanent scar. The only way I know of to set it right is to go back out there. To lock yourself in with the same woman who had tortured you so badly, and turn it all around on her.

That was what I'd whispered in Danni's ear. A bald request that needed no explanation.

Make her fear you.

Seeing that look on Danni's face all those months ago had pained me to no end. I was smiling now because she had given me what I'd asked for. She had put the fear back where it belonged.

On the face of her opponent.

Cole kept her distance, trying in vain to find somewhere to hide. Then her eyes went wide as she realized she wasn't the only one who wanted this to end... because Danni was coming again. Her guard was up high, her elbows were in tight, and there was no mistaking the grim determination in her stride.

If I were Cheryl, I'd have been looking for a place to hide, too.

She succeeded for a little while. Twice, she managed to circle out of danger before Danni could get to her. It was embarrassing because it looked exactly like what it was: Cheryl running away. But Cole didn't seem too worried about appearances. All she wanted to do was survive.

In the end, it didn't work out for her.

As Danni pushed her opponent back again, Cole sensed the fence coming and tried to slide right. Danni saw it, and took a full, purposeful step to her left to cut her off. For a moment, it looked like she'd overcommitted and left the other side wide-open. But when Cole tried to reverse direction, Danni's right hand shot out. Pressing her open palm to Cheryl's chest, she put her weight behind it and shoved the Brit into the fence. Like a bully throwing her prey against the back wall of the school before demanding her lunch money.

But there was no way for Cheryl to buy her way out of this one.

Left-right.

Two big punches that found their mark before Cole could react. Her guard came up high, but it was sloppy and she offered no counter to go with it. Danni was free to pick her angles, and her fists continued to find their way to Cheryl's face. Cole desperately grabbed at her tormentor's hands and tried to tie them up. Danni rolled right along with it. She tied Cheryl up instead and then came the knees. One, two, three, four... each separate and deliberate as she made sure she had Cole lined up perfectly so she could inflict maximum damage. She was in full control as she simply destroyed her opponent's body, and I swear - despite the blood and sweat - that I saw tears on Cole's face.

Cole got more aggressive in trying to tangle Danni up, and the two fighters settled into a long grapple as they battled for position. For a moment, it looked like Cheryl had managed to stop the onslaught. Then, with a sudden explosive push, Danni threw Cole back into fence and pulled her hands free. Cole was slow to react and Danni's right hand sailed in, landing full blast on Cheryl's jaw. Cole got her hands up to defend. Natural instinct battled with her training, and instinct won out. Her guard slid right, maximizing protection of the newly injured body part. Forgetting that the next strike was likely to come from Danni's other hand.

The left hook landed without interference, and I was pretty sure Cheryl was out. But fighters think in combinations, and Danni wasn't done. Right hook, left hook... both pounding Cole's gut. Yi recognized Cole was no longer defending and surged forward to stop the beating. Too slow. Danni finished the combo with a picture perfect uppercut that made a scary crack when it struck the underside of Cole's chin.

From opening hook to closing uppercut, the combo had taken less than three seconds. So much damage in so little time.

Again, my world moved into slow motion. Cole's body drifted up and back with the force of the final blow. Danni heard Yi yelling for her to back off, and she dutifully took a big step back to make room. Cheryl's body rocked back against the cage, then immediately pitched forward. Yi was racing to get there, but she was too far away. Cole was going down, and going down hard... until Danni stepped back in. Using both hands, she steadied her unconscious opponent against the fence for the brief moment it took for the ref to arrive and take over.

It was a move that summed up everything I love about her. Here, in her moment of glorious triumph, her first instinct had been to save Cheryl. Not because she cared or because she owed it to her or even because she thought letting her opponent fall would make her look bad. She did it simply because that's who she is.

Suddenly, I could no longer explain or even understand why I had resisted my relationship with Danni for so long. That night when she told me how she felt, I should have grabbed onto her with both hands, pulled her to me and promised I would never let go.

Yi eased Cheryl to the canvas as Danni quietly retreated to the other side of the cage. Medics poured in, and Steph and the others made way to let Cheryl's team follow them through. Mandy was jumping up and down with her fist in the air, but her little party ended abruptly once she got through the door and saw Danni squatted down on her haunches, stoically watching Cole. Steph went over, put a hand on Danni's

shoulder and leaned over to say something in her ear. Danni nodded and said something back without expression.

Why don't RSI fighters act like idiots when they win? Because Danni shows them how it's done. No matter the circumstances, she is always keenly aware of her surroundings and the seriousness that comes with knocking another woman unconscious. Cheryl Cole was a talker. A brash, arrogant woman who loved to lord it over her defeated opponents. After the shit she'd said, Danni could have climbed the cage in celebration, and no one would have thought it inappropriate. But Danni would never have forgiven herself.

Soon enough, Cole began to stir. Her team got her sitting up, and the medics started running through their checklists. One of them drifted over to ask Danni a few questions, but she was quickly satisfied that the new tournament champion was just fine.

With Cole up and moving, the smiles broke out on the RSI side. Hugs were exchanged all around, with Danni having to force Mandy to stop bouncing so they could embrace. Then Danni's head came up and she started looking around the cage. I knew immediately who she was looking for, and she found me right where she'd left me. I gave her a huge smile. She smiled back, then waved at me to come into the cage. I kept smiling as I shook my head.

I didn't know what was wrong with me. One second, I wanted to cheer. The next, I wanted to cry. The one after that, I wanted to race into the cage and throw my arms around her... and then, who knew? Emotions were rushing over me. Some were electric. Others were confusing. I couldn't and didn't trust that I would not make a very public spectacle of myself.

Danni waved more urgently, but I held my ground. For a moment, I thought she was going to march out and get me, but Natasha Yi saved me by calling her to the center for the official announcement. To my surprise, a very groggy Cole was there, too. When Danni saw her, she stepped across and offered her hand, but there was no warmth in the gesture. In fact, it was the most contempt I'd ever seen her publicly show for an opponent. Which told me plenty while telling the rest of the world nothing. Cheryl shook the hand - though she didn't look particularly happy about it - and then they both took their positions beside Yi.

Though she remained calm and contained, there was no hiding the smile on Danni's face. She didn't seem to want it to be there, and you could see how hard she was struggling to suppress it. But she was losing. Badly.

The ring announcer went to work.

Ladies AAAAND gentlemen... at four minutes and eighteen seconds into round five... your Fall Tournament Welterweight champion... byyyyyy KNOCKOUT... DA-neeeeeeeel HAR-RIIIIIIS!

This time I waited. The tournament was over, and I had no place urgent to be. I put my elbows up on the apron and rested my head on my hands as I watched the league president present Danni with the belt. I smiled broadly as Steph and Mandy got it looped around her waist. I let the roar of the crowd rumble deep into my soul and imagined the thrill this had to be for her. I let everything else go.

I decided to forget I was the owner of *Rampage Sports*. I didn't think at all about what we'd accomplished at this event, or where we'd go from here.

I pushed my messy, tangled emotions aside. I was confused, but not afraid. Somehow, I knew that everything would be alright.

For about ten minutes or so, I just stood there and enjoyed seeing my friend soak in one of the greatest moments of her career.

For those ten minutes, I was nothing more than Danni's biggest fan.